



Polytechnic University of Setúbal

Action Plan 2025-26



Preamble

This report constitutes the action plan of **Polytechnic University of Setúbal (IPS)** on its Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) related activities for 2025/2026. Substantial parts of IPS strategy, organization, and assessment processes align with the guiding principles of CoARA. The document has been developed based on a collaborative work and is organized with the frames of *Organizational Tasks*, *Quality Assurance System for Research, Science Staff and Senior Staff Scientists*, and *Activities 25/26*.

Organizational Tasks

A fundamental condition for addressing the challenges identified within the framework of CoARA (Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment) is to maintain and further develop an efficient institutional structure. IPS aims to ensure a streamlined organization with broad mandates and clearly defined responsibilities at each level of decision-making. Institutional governance should be complemented by strong leadership from school directors, course coordinators, department heads, and R&D coordinators.

Close collaboration with effective support structures, both centrally and within each academic unit, is crucial. IPS's governance model promotes structured dialogue across its organizational components, which is a cornerstone of its quality assurance efforts. The institutional culture fosters engagement and a shared sense of responsibility among staff for the overall functioning of the institution. Furthermore, it enables institutional leadership to understand the diversity of conditions and opportunities within different departments, supporting flexible and responsive management practices.

IPS also engages in structured strategic planning, action plans, and operational monitoring, which serve as important tools for quality assurance. Researchers at IPS operate in a constantly evolving environment shaped by scientific, political, financial, and societal dynamics. To ensure the ongoing relevance and impact of its activities, IPS embraces an organizational approach that supports flexibility and responsiveness. This is why the institution emphasizes trust-based practices, peer review, and the use of internal expertise to understand and address the specific challenges, opportunities, and contexts of its work.

Most of the research-related peer review at IPS takes place in the daily academic activities of its schools and departments, and R&D units. This includes the evaluation of publications, funding applications, science communication, hiring and promotion processes for R&D, as well as periodic application for calls conducted by external bodies such as the Portuguese Foundation for Science and Technology (FCT) and other national or international organizations.

Quality Assurance System for Research

Assuming quality management as a central element of the institutional strategy for the continuous improvement of its activities, IPS has defined a quality management and assurance system, organized according to its organizational context. This system, which identifies the responsibilities of the various departments and services in this field, as well as the involvement and responsibilities of students and other stakeholders in quality assurance processes, derives from the IPS Quality Policy, according to which IPS responds to the needs of its stakeholders.

The Main Research and Development Process encompasses all activities developed in this context, based on the Research and Development Policy, which defines the strategic objectives of the IPS in this area, as well as the institution's main lines of action, particularly about the necessary strategic alignment with the activity of the R&D units.

Subprocesses:

- 1 R&D+i Projects
- 2 R&D Units
- 3 Entrepreneurship and Knowledge and Technology Transfer
- 4 Intellectual Property

Science Staff and Senior Staff Scientists

At the Polytechnic Institute of Setúbal (IPS), research is understood as a collective endeavour that goes beyond the work of individual researchers. High-quality, innovative research depends not only on academic leadership, but also on the essential contributions of dedicated support staff. These professionals, often with strong backgrounds in science and technology, play a vital role in sustaining research environments, ensuring technical excellence, and enabling the success of complex projects.

In this context, IPS recognizes the importance of building a professional and career-supportive structure for technical and scientific staff involved in research support. These individuals contribute significantly to areas such as project management, data analysis, scientific instrumentation, research compliance, project administration, and technology transfer. Their expertise often overlaps with that of academic staff, and their responsibilities require continuous upskilling and deep familiarity with the scientific landscape. It is therefore crucial that their roles are formally acknowledged and integrated into institutional strategies for research development.

Although the Portuguese higher education system presents its own legal and structural terms of career progression IPS is committed to addressing this issue through clear recognition pathways and appropriate institutional frameworks.

Such roles would not only reflect the complexity and importance of the work carried out by support staff but would also help retain talent and foster long-term institutional knowledge. By establishing transparent criteria for hiring, evaluation, and internal promotion, IPS aims to provide these professionals with meaningful career trajectories within the institution. In the longer term, this approach will strengthen the overall quality and sustainability of research at IPS.

Moreover, the creation and formalization of research support positions would align IPS with international trends in research management and governance, including principles advocated by the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA). Recognizing a broader range of research contributors is essential to building inclusive, effective, and well-functioning research ecosystems. It also reinforces IPS's commitment to equity, excellence, and the responsible development of science and innovation.

To support this objective, IPS encourages the ongoing professional development of technical and administrative staff through training, international collaboration, and participation in research activities. The institution also seeks to foster a stronger integration between research teams and support structures, ensuring that all staff involved in research have access to the tools, knowledge, and opportunities they need to thrive.

Activities 2025/2026

- **R&D Units Evaluation by FCT:** assessment of research units for the period 2025/2029.
- **IPS Recruitment Policy for Open, Transparent, and Merit-based Recruitment (OTM-R).** As one of the pillars of the European Charter for Researchers, which sets out a set of general principles regarding the responsibilities and rights of researchers and IPS. These principles aim to promote a stimulating work environment that supports the production, transfer, and sharing of knowledge, as well as the professional development of researchers.
- **HRS4R:** IPS has formalized its commitment to recognizing and valuing the importance of research activities by adhering to the European Charter for Researchers and adopting its 40 principles in the development of its strategy for the continuous improvement of the conditions of human resources allocated to research for 2025. In May 2025, IPS has been accredited with the seal for the Human Resources Excellence in Research (HRS4R) by EURAXESS. The seal for HR Excellence in Research is awarded to organizations that define a set of actions to improve their practices in human resources allocated to research.

- **Infrastructure:** IPS is currently expanding its Students Residences, which can be used to temporarily accommodate invited researchers. Also, the building of the School of Health is under construction, and a new building in Sines will be constructed to accommodate a new School.
- **Open Science Practices:** The adoption of open science practices is increasingly acknowledged as an indicator of excellence in both research and education.
- **Participation in the activities of the Portuguese National Chapter.**

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